Transformation of Media Relations in Bangladesh: A Critical Analysis of the Role of New Media

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Abstract

This paper conducts a comprehensive analysis of media relationships in Bangladesh throughout the previous 20 years, focusing strongly on new media. Rapid advancements in mobile technologies along with growth in internet access and Facebook and YouTube social networks, have transformed how information gets generated and moves across networks for consumption. State-controlled traditional media lost its exclusive communication position when digital platforms emerged which give power to citizens alongside journalists and political actors to bypass censorship systems for direct communication. New media proves its strength by driving political activism during the Shahbagh Movement and achieving the Digital Bangladesh campaign goals, according to the study. examines the digital integration effects on journalism practice along with political communication and public relations operations throughout Bangladesh. The research acknowledges major obstacles that emerge from digital misinfo, digital surveillance, and ethical concerns, as well as harassment incidents along with digital inequality. New media can fully fulfill its democratic potential in Bangladesh's changing media environment by improving digital literacy while ensuring ethical journalism through inclusive infrastructure and transparent policy frameworks.

Introduction

The media environment in Bangladesh underwent a significant transformation during the past twenty years, which transformed information creation and distribution processes. The rapid development of new media technologies such as social networking sites, coupled with mobile internet and user-generated content platforms, has driven this extensive transformation. During previous times, media relations in Bangladesh operated under government control through state-run newspapers alongside radio and television, which functioned as the main news and information sources for the public. The traditional media establishments followed exact editorial protocols while officials monitored them for censorship (Rahman, 2013, p. 45). News and information transmission followed official channels that directed content exclusively toward receiver groups, which mainly stayed passive.

Digital technology adoption during the mid-2000s established a new information paradigm. The combination of cheap mobile technology along with cheap internet access created conditions for millions of Bangladeshi citizens to access current information while sharing creative media content with the public. Digital usage in Bangladesh experienced rapid growth during the last two years because the country gained more than 123 million internet users according to Islam and Ahmed (2020, para. 3), and these users were actively present on Facebook, YouTube, and WhatsApp platforms.

The advent of digital technology transformed the fundamental methods through which people in Bangladesh conduct their media relations. Social media platforms serve as fundamental platforms for public social discussion alongside political discussions and deliver vital platforms for activism and crisis response, and marketing functions. The public now receives information directly from media outlets and journalists because these groups and public relations professionals and civil society organizations,s and political leaders are bypassing traditional media intermediaries through new media platforms. Audience participation through media interactivity has transformed media-audience dynamics, which now creates an active public communication environment throughout Bangladesh. The emergence of citizen journalism has become a formidable media force. Average members of society perform news reporting duties while livestreaming protests and uncovering corruption, with their comments conveying alternative perspectives that precede traditional media coverage. The widespread distribution of media content through citizen journalists benefits transparency and inclusivity, yet it produces worries about misinformation alongside fake news distribution and electronic abuse (Hasan, 2018, para. 5). Algorithms and echo chambers work together to push political polarisation, which hinders media relations and destroys social cohesion.

The shifts in Bangladesh produce a combination of profound changes, together with continuous disruptions. The government of Bangladesh established the Digital Security Act 2018, yet this legislation faces criticism because of its potential interference with free speech, according to Chowdhury (2018, p. 14). Modern media professionals maintain dual roles between traditional methods as well as emerging digital platforms, which sometimes boost or directly challenge one another. Media relations operate at greater complexity in today's world as they face multiple communication directions, together with fast-moving technological advancements and shifting political landscapes.

Historical Context of Media Relations in Bangladesh

Post-independence Bangladesh experienced a time when the media ran under intense state supervision, particularly during its initial years. The administration exercised strict control over information distribution because it allowed minimal opportunities for alternative viewpoints to emerge. The media received freedom as private television channels emerged in the 1990s, which widened content choices and viewpoints according to Rahman (2013), page 45. Traditional media relations operated based on a top-down model where official sources sent information through official channels to reach the public audience. Journalists depended mainly on selected government sources, such as press releases, while delivering information that went through pre-established limits of distribution.

At that time, the Bangladesh Television (BTV) and Bangladesh Betar (radio) controlled broadcast news services alongside the two national newspapers, "Ittefaq" and "The Daily Star,"

keeping the print segment thriving. During times of political unrest, media organizations received censorship orders on top of their regulatory oversight by licensing authorities. During the military regimes of the 1980s, the government officially established complete control over the media to maintain adherence to official narratives. The media system experienced minor liberalization during the 1990s before digital networks brought about lasting changes in communication methods.

Emergence and Growth of New Media

A digital transformation started to take effect in Bangladesh during the early parts of the 2000s. The widespread availability of digital technology and platforms, including Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube dramatically modified how people handle information dissemination processes. Over 100 million Bangladeshis were using the internet in 2020, while a considerable number of them maintained active social media profiles (Islam & Ahmed, 2020, para. 3). Digital platforms gave rise to new content-producing citizens who directly challenged the media gatekeepers and shifted traditional relationships in news media.

Mobile data plans and affordable smartphones proved essential to shut down the information divide between metropolitan populations and rural residents. By 2020, the Bangladesh Telecommunication Regulatory Commission showed that mobile phone penetration rose above 90%, along with internet penetration topping 60%. Social media now functions as the main platform people use to distribute information, while using it for activism and general public discussion. Through citizen journalism, which uses mobile phones for documentation, ordinary people have multiplied reporting channels, thereby achieving instant event coverage that previously received no media attention.

Industrial journalism has been forced to implement new business plans through the digital transformation of news production facilities. Print newspapers continue their operations by managing active internet platforms along with social media profiles to extend their target audience. The newspapers "Prothom Alo" and "The Daily Star" obtained vast online audiences, which surpass their traditional print distribution numbers. The adjustment necessitated the examination of media relations approaches by both journalists and organizations and government bodies.

Impact of New Media on Traditional Media Relations

The advent of new media diminished the practices of conventional media relations through multiple disruptive transformations. The new media system provided everyone from traditional sources to ordinary individuals with tools to share information on a vast scale. The new media landscape made traditional media lose their authority which eventually led them to include digital platforms into their operational structure. Traditional journalists received pressure to speed up their reporting from new media while sacrificing complete fact-checking practices according to Hasan (2018, para. 5). Through new media platforms public figures gained the ability to communicate directly with the general population thereby lowering their need for traditional media offerings as intermediaries.

Traditional media needed to change their practices because of this development. Newspapers implemented social media tracking tools to detect what stories were becoming popular among the public. Journalists started receiving news materials from social media services including Twitter and Facebook which resulted in the loss of professional versus amateur reporting distinctions. News organizations developed digital platforms that integrated both professional journalist work and content contributed by readers.

News production methods alongside consumer behavior significantly changed because of this change. Newspapers employed to present curated content to readers but audiences now use personalized feeds alongside algorithmic recommendations to shape their news consumption. Traditional news outlets face challenges retaining their authority while maintaining audience trust as news consumption has become fragmented within decentralized online media.

Political Communication and New Media

The influence of new media on political communication throughout Bangladesh has been substantial. Through social media platforms, political parties, together with their leaders, have built channels that help them reach constituents and broadcast messages while strengthening their supporter base. Through the 2013 Shahbagh Movement, activists proved how new media platforms could direct protests for capital punishment against war criminals, according to Chowdhury (2018, p. 12).

The rise of political actors using Facebook Live, along with YouTube broadcasting and Twitter social media, has created new direct communication methods for them. The political communication tools of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina depend heavily on her official Facebook page. These digital channels provide leaders with a way around standard media professionals to send their messages directly into the public domain. This increased accessibility contributes to

greater transparency but creates risks of unverified propaganda alongside false information circulating without regulation.

Election campaigns utilize social media platforms as a prominent tool that stands out among other strategies. Both political parties conducted intense social media campaigns in the 2018 electoral cycle while targeting millennial voter audiences. The increased efforts to engage youth through social media platforms triggered public concerns about disinformation campaigns alongside fake news and cyberbullying. These regulatory systems have faced difficulty adapting to new digital developments and thus digital manipulation has become a possibility.

Public Relations and New Media Integration

The evolution of Public Relations (PR) practices in Bangladesh happened through the integration of new media. Social media platforms have become central tools which private and governmental organizations use to control their public perception and reach their stakeholders and deliver relevant information. The Directorate General of Health Services utilized its Facebook page as an effective platform to share health guidelines throughout the COVID-19 pandemic (Khan & Rahman, 2024, para. 4).

The adoption of digital PR strategies has become common practice in corporate businesses together with charity organizations and educational institutions. Organizations implement unique social media-focused content marketing combined with influencer outreach and crisis management mechanisms. Grameenphone together with bKash implement consistent Facebook and YouTube strategies to communicate with customers and resolve problems along with enhancing brand affinity.

Table-Top Exercise has introduced new capabilities which PR professionals need to acquire. The practice of writing press releases through conventional means no longer satisfies the current needs. Modern PR demands new competencies because skills which include social media analytics and digital storytelling and SEO (Search Engine Optimization) together with community management have become necessary for professionals. News about PR crises spread rapidly online which makes it necessary for organizations to develop immediate response strategies.

Case Studies

Shahbagh Movement

The Shahbagh Movement stands as a crucial case to understand how new media enabled political mobilization during 2013. Bloggers and online activists initiated the movement, which activists developed on social media into large-scale protests to execute war criminals. The movement demonstrated how digital platforms create public opinion shifts and make it possible to unite people for action (Chowdhury, 2018, p. 15).

Social media tools, including Facebook events and YouTube videos, and Twitter hashtags, enabled the movement to pass geographical limitations and unite Bangladeshis who lived across the world. The participants employed online live broadcasting for speeches while sharing protest schedules and distributing posters digitally. National policy decisions received input from the digitally sustained public pressure. The new media tactics used by the movement encountered opposition as well as praise, revealing its unique characteristics.

Digital Bangladesh Campaign

The "Digital Bangladesh" campaign initiated its mission to convert Bangladesh into a knowledge-based society in 2009, while targeting 2021 as the target date. The initiative pursued internet expansion while advocating for e-governance along with Information and Communication Technologies integration across different sectors. New media implementation enabled the campaign to successfully connect with its citizens while distributing information about government accomplishments, which improved both transparency and public engagement (Rahman, 2013, p. 65).

The government made web portals and mobile apps alongside digital notice boards available for people to access their services. Official platforms such as YouTube channels, together with Facebook pages, performed the essential role of promoting digital initiatives to the public. Despite its extensive progress in modernizing ICT across Bangladesh, the program received opposition claiming digital tools do not automatically provide citizens with digital literacy and democratic participation abilities.

Challenges and Ethical Concerns

The incorporation of new media into Bangladesh's media relations brought about a new communication period with important ethical problems in addition to substantial challenges. Widespread distribution of misleading content including fake news operates as one of the main current challenges. Misinformation on Facebook YouTube and WhatsApp reaches millions of

users at high speed thus causing severe damage. Nine types of content coerce readers into emotional responses by using sensational narratives thereby breaking down trust in media sources while distorting real information to spark both public and political unrest. The spread of false and damaging information becomes worse due to ineffective regulations that should prevent or punish these false content distribution delays.

Journalists together with media professionals in Bangladesh must tackle new ethical problems that were nearly non-existent when digital media did not exist. The need for instant news generation during the permanent news coverage and digital audience interaction standards drives many journalists to produce reports hastily. The failure to maintain accuracy alongside verification and maintain journalistic integrity occurs when this happens. Creating a harmonious balance between being first to publish news and reporting honestly proves exceptionally tough to establish. The use of user-generated content available without verification creates serious issues regarding reliability because inaccurate materials easily get distorted or extracted improperly (Hasan, 2018, para. 7).
Internet surveillance and harassment of journalists alongside activists together with marginalized groups has become a worrying new phenomenon. Female journalists face elevated risks on digital platforms because they regularly receive both gender-specific harassment and dangerous threats and intimidatory messages. The hostile online atmosphere from harassment makes people avoid participation and shifts them away from expressing their opinions freely. The 2018 Digital Security Act received criticism because its imprecise wording fuels concerns about abuse possibility despite being designed to combat cybercrime. Journalists and social media users alongside other individuals face arrest after expressing controversial opinions that authorities consider offensive which creates serious problems for free speech protection and civil rights preservation.

Digital inequality continues to be an acute problem which Bangladesh faces. Internet access has improved substantially through mobile networks yet significant differences persist between population groups in urban regions versus rural communities and between different social economic classes. A large segment of the citizenry remains without basic digital skills since they cannot obtain trustworthy internet services nor obtain digital devices. The creation of such a digital gap creates barriers to information society involvement and strengthens the existing disparities between social classes and economic status. A sizable proportion of people will stay outside the benefits of new media because of neglected digital infrastructure development together with insufficient education for digital literacy. As a result this will hurt the digital age goal of inclusive communication.

Conclusion

The advent of new media platforms in Bangladesh led to major changes in the creation and distribution along with consumption of information in media relations. The traditional government-run communication methods and established news media outlets no longer control the information flow as media relations have spread across multiple directions at a rapid speed. Through social media and digital tools citizens now possess the power to both engage directly with information and dispute official narratives while taking active part in forming public discussions.

Leaders and political parties have selected Facebook and YouTube platforms to directly reach voters since they bypass traditional media's filtering systems. Public relations strategies now focus on digital interactions and live exchanges along with establishing connections with influential figures who proved vital during COVID-19 and corporate outreach initiatives.

New media has introduced various difficulties along with its promising opportunities. Online security challenges which include the spread of misinformation together with unregulated practices and harassment activities as well as digital surveillance systems create ethical, accurate and free expression problems. Many citizens fail to engage in the modern communication system because they do not have access to digital tools and lack digital literacy.

The introduction of new media has both transformed media relations in Bangladesh along with creating fresh communication channels yet it continues to force the need for risk management. The complete utilization of this transformation depends on strengthening digital literacy and fostering ethical media practices while implementing fair regulations and addressing digital inequality. The full democratic and transparent development opportunities of new media will become accessible to Bangladesh when these conditions are established.

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